

CHAPTER 7

The High Cost of Higher Education

Postsecondary education is important; it gives you an edge. So it's hard to argue against more schooling, and it's something I won't do. Education has its own intrinsic value, and sometimes that doesn't necessarily translate into money. Many graduates end up with degrees that don't necessarily lead to lucrative careers, let alone the easy ability to pay back their student loans. That's why I believe education is education right up until you enter a postsecondary institution. After that, education becomes an investment, one that should be as carefully considered as where you're going to buy your first house. (Or *if* you're going to buy one. This is not a given.)

It varies from state to state, but tuition for an in-state undergraduate degree program costs, on average, between \$4,000 and \$15,000 a year. If you go to college out of state, the national average skyrockets to nearly \$22,000. And if you've got your heart set on a private college or university, get ready to pay *at least* \$29,000. The cost of grad school is even more formidable—you're looking at close to \$30,000 if you study medicine or law, \$37,000 if you want to be a dentist. These numbers don't include books, fees, room and board, transportation, or recreation, all of which add tens of thousands to the final bill. So after doubling and tripling some of those numbers, it wouldn't be uncommon for an average twenty-three-year-old with, say, a master's degree in education to graduate more than \$100,000 in debt.

That's a horribly depressing way to start out your young life. But here's the common rationalization of that kind of debt: *I'll get a good*